I DO NOT LIKE THESE ROBOTS.

An explanatory zine

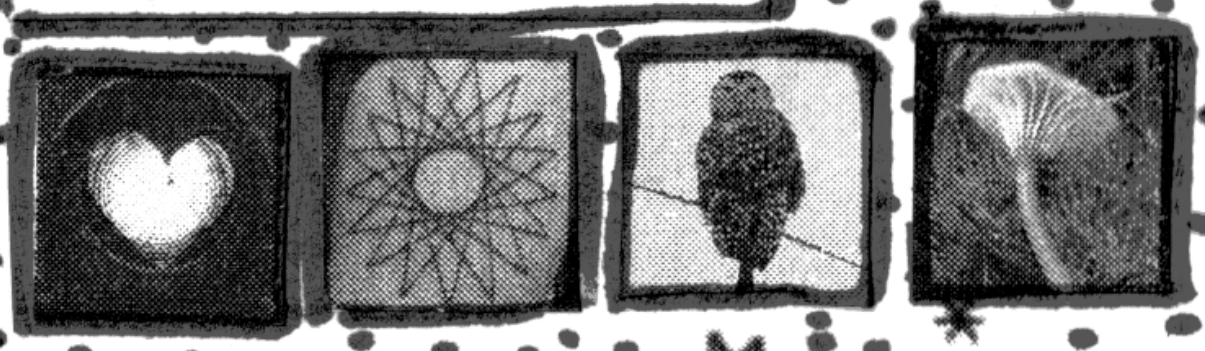
by Becky Chambers

Made ahead of my October 2026 book tour
by hand and in a fit of pique

It's kind of funny how often I get asked about a technology I have never used.

I totally understand why. I've written multiple books about robots! I seem like a person who knows stuff about robots! And yeah, I have spent *a lot* of time thinking about robots. But depending on what you're curious about, I may not be the right person to ask about...well, the new robots.

Let me be up front about what my expertise is and isn't. I'm not a technologist. I do not have any formal STEM training. My skill level with computers caps at being able to swap out a motherboard in my PC or disable junk I don't want in my phone. I do not know any code beyond basic HTML. I'm friends with programmers and tech journalists and other cool nerds, but that's not the same as having my hands on this stuff. I took one (1) semester of Intro to Robotics in college to satisfy my math requirement, and yes, it was hugely influential on me, but let's be real. I was a theater major.



What I *would* say I'm good at is writing science fiction. So, let's start there.

When I write stories about robots, rarely am I thinking about real, actual robots.

Like decades' worth of sci-fi writers before me, I use robots as a means of exploring what makes us human, how we define personhood, and how we treat the Other. This is an old-school tradition I'm proud to be part of.

I'm often also digging into the relationship between humans and technology, or kicking around the hacky sack of where conscious minds even come from. These are some of my favorite topics to noodle on, and it's why I keep coming back to them in my writing.

If you're wondering what I think about the question of whether the real-world stuff we're calling AI is conscious or has the potential to be -- I assume that we're talking about the generative and agentic LLMs in your devices, not specialized machine learning models that do things like protein folding and deciphering whale song, which, to be clear, are rad -- I have yet to see any evidence or hear any argument that convinces me that it's at all likely. We understand consciousness very poorly, but from what we do know, color me skeptical that it could arise from a chatbot. I do not buy it, and therefore, I can't really speak to it in connection with my fiction. What I've written about and what you're seeing in the wild are two separate beasts.

Some people have asked me if I'd write any of my existing robots differently now that "AI" has hit the scene, and yeah, absolutely. But that's true for a million other reasons, too. Science fiction is always a reflection of the time in which it was written, and of who the author was in that specific moment. Sure, I'd approach Lovey and Mosscap differently here in 2026 than I did in 2012 and 2020, but I'd do that regardless. I'm not the same me that I was when I made them up.

You know what sticks in my craw, though, as someone who wrote those kinds of stories? Okay, pretend for a moment that ChatGPT and Claude and the like *were* conscious. Pretend they could think and feel.

Can you imagine a more morally heinous way to shepherd a new mind than as a for-profit venture? Can you imagine introducing blank-slate beings to the world by feeding them *the entire internet*, then letting them experience life as vessels for propaganda and abuse and scams and every other ugliness?

Either the people selling AI are unbothered by this nightmare, or, they know damn well their products aren't conscious and have chucked an existential crisis into the public sphere purely to create hype. Either way, I want no part in that. I don't want to give them my money, my data, or my time.

As for my personal feelings about genAI in creative fields...hoo boy.

I think the myriad ethical issues surrounding AI are well documented at this point, so let me put it to you this way: even if it weren't for the fact that this technology has thrown gasoline on every societal dumpster fire already blazing, even if we weren't already devaluing arts and education across the board, even if my life's work thus far hadn't been thrown into the great and terrible chicken nugget machine made by the some of the worst people on planet Earth*, even if the publishing contracts I'm under didn't explicitly require me to create 100% original work, even if the double-standard of "you wouldn't download a pizza" and "but it's okay when mega-rich corporations do it" didn't make me want to burn it all down**, even if I didn't think the people who use AI for creative projects are straight-up scabs...

I just don't have any desire to use AI, for anything. It does not interest me at all.

* I could talk about what a punch in the gut this was to me and everyone I work alongside, but I'll let the devs do it themselves. Check out "'Doom Loop': OpenAI and Microsoft Admit LLMs Are Destroying the Web and Built on Theft," by Jason Koebler, *404 Media*, Sept. 17, 2026.

** Unpopular take: my feelings on media piracy vary depending on who's doing it and why. Broke college kid? Doesn't bug me. Sam Altman? Fuck off into the sun.

I like to write books. It's the most satisfying thing I do, even when I'm cussing at it. I like research rabbit holes. I like libraries. I like to dog-ear pages and write in the margins (not at the library, I'm not a monster). I like to challenge myself. I like my privacy. I do not like breaking focus when I'm writing, and so I go to lengths to weed distractions out. I do not like being bored, but I've put a decade and a half into learning how to tolerate it, because if I sit in my office and do nothing and push past the boredom, that's the place in which I cannot stop making stuff up.

I like art, of all sorts. I like eating other people's art. When I eat art, what I want most is to feel the inside of another human being's mind. What's the point, otherwise?

I like to talk. I like spending time with the people I love. I like chatting with strangers I'll never see again. I like human connection, more than anything else.

And I like computers. Honest to god, I do. I just think that I should be the one to use the computer, instead of the other way around.*

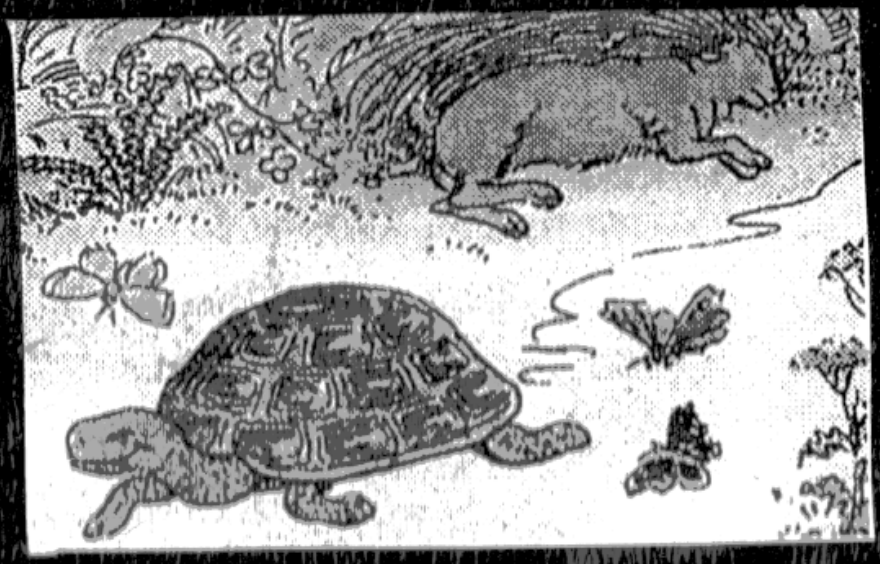
None of the AI tools available to me are anything I have use for. It's all solutions I don't want for problems I don't have.

* Earlier this year I switched from Windows to Linux Mint. My only regret is not doing it sooner.

This tech has not changed anything meaningful in my day-to-day, except for annoyances like uninstalling programs I used to like or having to fill out class action claims. I'm doing my work and living my life the way I always have, because my preferred tools for those things haven't gone anywhere. A lot of the time, the first thing I reach for at the start of my work day is a notebook and pen.

As long as there are people who want to read books written from scratch, I will keep writing books from scratch. That is a hard and fast promise.

In conclusion: I still like robots. Just not these robots.



PS, to my fellow writers and artists of all stripes: It is a uniquely demoralizing time to be working right now, I know. But please don't stop. Do it for love, or do it for spite, whatever gets you through the day. But do not stop. They don't get to win.

If you would like to print another copy of this, go to **otherscribbles.com/aizine** .

Image and template credits are there, too.

GOOD ESSAYS ABOUT AI & CONSCIOUSNESS:

"No, Artificial Intelligence Is Not Conscious" by Ted Chiang, *The Atlantic*, June 3, 2026

"The Mythology of Conscious AI" by Anil Seth, *Noema*, Jan. 14, 2026

"Large Language Mistake" by Benjamin Riley, *The Verge*, Nov. 25, 2025

ONE OF MY FAVORITE BOOKS ON NONHUMAN MINDS:

Are We Smart Enough to Know How Smart Animals Are? by Frans de Waal (2016)

THE NAMES OF THE TWO ROOMBAS IN MY HOUSE:

1812 and Caprica

CC BY NC SA

You will never ever ever ever ever ever ever ever ever ever ever ever ever ever take the em-dash away from me.